

# PRE-SUASION

A Revolutionary Way to Influence and Persuade

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## The Big "So What"

Pre-suasion is about laying the groundwork so your recipients are already receptive to your message by the time you present it. Such tactics are based on scientific principles that *can* be learned and systematically applied. By mastering pre-suasion techniques, you can influence and persuade others more effectively, be it to get your kids' cooperation at home or to win over clients in business.



## Introduction



After studying professionals in various industries, Cialdini found that the best persuaders spend more time crafting what to say/do *before* making a request. They influence behaviors not by improving the product features or offer, but by presenting them in a way that's the most psychologically appealing. In short, **to persuade effectively, you must first learn to pre-suade effectively.**

- Pre-suasion is achieved through specific actions, framing and conscious/subconscious cues, strategically placed at the right time.
- This summary is organized into 2 parts:
  - (i) Sources of pre-suasion (and why they work); and
  - (ii) Putting pre-suasion to work

## KEY QUOTES

*"To persuade optimally...it's necessary to pre-suade optimally."*

*"The highest achievers spent more time crafting what they did and said before making a request."*

*"The basic idea of pre-suasion is that by guiding preliminary attention strategically, it's possible for a communicator to move recipients into agreement with a message before they experience it."*



## Sources of Pre-Suasion (and Why they Work)



### The Importance of Attention

Human beings can only focus on 1 thing at a time—once something grabs our attention, we ignore everything else. In addition, we don't make decisions based on the most helpful or correct inputs. **We make decisions based on the inputs we happen to be focusing on at that moment.**



**Privileged Moments** are observable points in time when someone becomes especially receptive to a message being communicated.

- It's easier to confirm or look for something that's present, than to disconfirm or notice something that's missing. When searching our memory, we naturally look for hits rather than misses. So, you can tell someone on 1 day that he's hard-headed and on another day that he's flexible. Both times, he'll agree because he'll recall different events to confirm the trait being brought to focus.
- Single-chute questions are biased, one-sided questions that lead people to confirm a viewpoint. You can use them to create privileged moments where people become vulnerable to related suggestions. In a study, only 33% of people agreed to leave their contact details so they could be sent a new soft drink sample. However, when they were first asked if they were adventurous and liked to try new things (to which 97% said yes), 75.7% later agreed to leave their contacts. By getting people to focus on a belief or perception, you can get them to say "yes" to a related suggestion.



**Focusing illusion:** Because of our limited attention, we assume that whatever we're focusing on is more important. This means that **a communicator can get us to place undue importance on something (e.g. a feature or message) just by drawing our attention narrowly to it.** This is commonly done in 3 ways:

### KEY QUOTES

*"The guiding factor in a decision is often not the one that counsels most wisely; it's one that has recently been brought to mind."*

*"It is easier to register the presence of something than its absence."*

*"Nothing in life is as important as you think it is while you are thinking about it."  
—Daniel Kahneman*

- Subtle cues in the background (e.g. noise, images or music) can subconsciously influence our decisions. For example, different backgrounds were tested on the landing page of an online furniture store. Visitors who landed on a page with clouds focused more on comfort in their search for sofas; those who landed on a page with pennies focused more on price.
- Innocent questions or surveys can direct us to focus on a specific option or trait to sway our preferences. Leaders in an organization were each asked to do a survey about a different solution—invariably, they ended up recommending the solution that they were surveyed on. Likewise, by getting customers to complete a survey about your product, you can draw their attention to your strong qualities so they'll favorably consider your brand. The key is to focus on just 1 *benefit* without drawing attention to other alternatives.
- Our opinion can be shaped by the issues or facts we're most exposed to. For example, something that's covered extensively in the news will seem more significant. During the US' military campaign Iraq in 2003, the Bush administration cleverly embedded reporters in the combat units. This skewed the news coverage (and public attention) to the everyday life of the soldiers instead of why the war was happening in the first place.



**Assumed causality.** The more we focus on something, the more we're likely to believe that it's the cause of a problem or behavior.

- Such causal links can be totally illogical. In 1982, Johnson & Johnson recalled all Tylenol pills from the shelves due to drug tampering, and issued numbers to help consumers identify the different Tylenol batches. U.S. residents actually started to run lotteries using those numbers—just because the numbers were highly visible from media publicity, people believed they had a better chance of winning lottery with them.
- People with greater visibility are also assumed to be more responsible for both good and bad outcomes.

## KEY QUOTES

*"A communicator who gets an audience to focus on a key element of a message pre-loads it with importance."*

*"Anything that draws focused attention to itself can lead observers to overestimate its importance."*

*"The press may not be successful most of the time in telling people what to think, but it is stunningly successful in telling them what to think about."*

—Bernard Cohen

*"The brain's operations arise fundamentally and inescapably from raw associations."*

- (i) The more visible someone is, the more influential they seem. This explains why leaders are often assumed to be responsible for the success or failure of their team, even though there're other factors involved, e.g. staff quality, business systems or market conditions.
- (ii) When police interrogations are recorded as evidence for trials, the camera angle makes a huge difference. If the camera is aimed directly at the suspect, he's more likely to be seen as guilty. If the camera is angled sideways (with equal focus on the suspect and questioner), that bias disappears. If the camera is focused on the interrogator, observers tend to believe the suspect is being coerced.



### *Attracting and Holding Attention*

We're attracted to stimuli that are relevant to our survival or goals, and tend to pay more attention to unfinished tasks.



We are drawn to things that're relevant to our survival:

- We involuntarily pay attention to changes in our environment. Advertisers target this primal instinct by cutting to specific parts of a message they want the audience to focus on. They also use contrast or novelty to pre-suade people. When presented with 2 brands of sofas, 58% of research participants chose durability over comfort. But when they were presented with 4 sofas—3 that were more durable and 1 that was more comfortable —77% chose comfort because of the contrast.
- Sex appeal is a proven stimulus that's widely used in advertising. However, it only works if you're selling a related product e.g. cosmetics or tight-fitting clothes. It does *not* work for unrelated items, e.g. detergents or kitchen appliances.
- Violence and fear are also powerful attention-grabbers.
  - (i) In fact, people may end up putting themselves at greater risks just to avoid a perceived threat. After the 9/11 terrorist attacks, many Americans chose road travel

## KEY QUOTES

*"Whenever we first register a change around us, our attention flies to it."*

instead of air travel, not realizing that the casualty rate from car accidents was actually much higher.

(ii) To change bad habits, it's more effective to show the negative effects of bad habits than the positive effects of good ones, provided you also include actionable steps to overcome the problem. Anti-smoking messages on cigarette packages are more effective if they display both the harmful effects of smoking and advice on how to stop smoking.

- The stimuli you're exposed to can influence how you react to subsequent messages. People who've just been exposed to sexual stimuli will respond positively to an ad to "stand out from the crowd". People who've just been exposed to violence or threats will respond better to an ad with the message: "Everyone else is doing this, don't miss out".



We also focus on self-relevant topics (i.e. info about ourselves) or information that match our goals. Marketing messages are more effective when they use "you" instead of "people" or "they". People pay more attention to (and remember) health information that includes relevant data about their age, gender or health history.



The Zeigarnik effect says that we pay much more attention to unfinished tasks than completed ones. When a task is incomplete, we remember the details and feel a nagging sense of incompleteness if we're pulled away from the task. However, once a task is finished, our cognitive attention is directed elsewhere.

- Use incomplete tasks to counter procrastination. If you're a writer, don't end a writing session with a complete paragraph or thought, even if you know exactly what to say. Keep it for the next session so you'll itch to get back to work.
- Use mysteries to capture and hold people's attention. If you're a teacher, begin/end each class with an unfinished mystery, so your students will remember the details needed to solve the puzzle.

## KEY QUOTES

*"When recipients get a message that is self relevant... they are more likely to lend it attention, find it interesting, take it seriously, remember it and save it for future reference."*

*"Not completing an activity can make everything about it more memorable."*

*"One's attention is magnetized to the mystery story because of its inherent, unresolved nature."*

↔ **Counter-arguments** can be more effective than direct arguments, especially if they present rivals in bad light. Combine mystery with counter-arguments using these steps: Present the mystery → Deepen it with data/questions → Present alternative answers then refute them to lead in to your answer → Give a clue on the right answer → Solve the mystery → Explain the implications.



## The Power of Association

Every idea in our mind is linked to network of concepts, images and feelings. By using certain words, metaphors, or external/internal cues, we can get people to unconsciously focus on associated thoughts and feelings, and hence shape their choices and behaviors.

👁️ **Language & visual associations.** Strong communicators use language to conjure mental associations that are favorable to their messages. In a study, fund-raisers at a call-center were given information about how their work impacts the community. One group received printed text while the other had an additional picture of a runner winning a race. The second group raised 60% more money, illustrating the power of visual associations.

🧑 **Metaphors** help listeners to understand something by associating it with another image. They frame how people think, thus influencing their subsequent choices.

- Simply by changing the metaphor, politicians can influence people to support different approaches to the same problem. When crime rates were likened to a ravaging beast, people opted for a solution to catch and imprison criminals. When crime rates were depicted as a virus, people preferred a solution to tackle the underlying conditions that led to its spread.
- We're also influenced by non-verbal metaphors. A warm cup of tea can make us feel warmer toward the people around us. Reading a resume without a clipboard (or reading a book on lightweight kindle) can also make the content seem lighter or more trivial.

## KEY QUOTES

*In contests of persuasion, counter arguments are typically more powerful than arguments”.*

*“We should think of language as primarily a mechanism of influence.”*

*“He who wants to persuade should put his trust not in the right argument but in the right word.”*

—Joseph Conrad

*“If you want to change the world, change the metaphor.”*  
—Joseph Campbell



We can also shape behavior by changing people's external and internal environments.

- External cues from our physical surroundings can prompt us to focus on certain memories, traits or feelings. Audience in a dermatology lecture often start to scratch themselves after hearing about skin irritations. A team of consultants found that pinning up clients' pictures in the meeting rooms helped them to keep their discussions focused on the clients' needs. A writer will unconsciously adopt a more academic writing style if he's in a university, and a more casual writing style if he's in a laid-back neighborhood café.
- We can create positive self-influence by shifting our internal focus away from dis-empowering thoughts (e.g. anxiety, inadequacy) to empowering ones (e.g. strengths, past successes).
  - (i) Studies found that people felt happier just by adopting 3 practices to shift their focus: (a) list down what they're grateful for at the start of the day, (b) choose to look at possibilities and positives, and (c) limit the time spent dwelling on unhappy events.
  - (ii) Just before you start an exam, don't do last-minute cramming or worry about what you don't know. Use that time to recap your strengths and past academic successes.
- You can use pre-suasive cues to achieve your goals. Develop "if/when-then plans" by (i) defining situation-specific cues where you can advance your goals and (ii) linking them to the desired actions. For example, to lose weight, you can develop a plan like this: "If/when I'm offered a soft drink during a meal, I'll ask for green tea instead."



We also tend to over-value things that're connected to or similar to us. We feel an affinity with people who share our birthday, name, language etc. Even organizations tend to overvalue things that include elements of their name or identity. In 2004, the Rolling Stones Magazine selected top 500 songs of the rock era, of which the top 2 were "Like a Rolling Stone" by Bob Dylan and "Satisfaction" by the Rolling Stones.

## KEY QUOTES

*"Steering attention from one feature of a person's inner geography to another can affect performance."*

*"When we grasp something fluently—that is, we can picture or process it quickly and effortlessly—we not only like that thing more but also think it is more valid and worthwhile."*



We're also biased toward things that are easy to grasp, visualize or do. We prefer rhymes, names that're easy to pronounce, and tasks that're easy to finish. All things being equal, companies on the US stock exchange with pronounceable names or stock ticker codes tend to perform better initially than companies with foreign-sounding or unpronounceable names.



## Managing Pre-suasion and its Biases/Influences



When our brain is exposed to an “opener concept”, it quickly links to other related concepts. It's like opening the doors to related ideas, while *concurrently* closing the doors to irrelevant ideas.

- Video game players tend to become more antisocial after playing aggressive games, but more helpful after playing prosocial games. Interestingly, violent video games that require cooperation with others lead to *less* aggressive post-game behaviors, because the very act of cooperation suppresses aggressive associations.
- The stronger the link between the opener concept and related concept, the stronger the pre-suasive effects. Subjects who see photos of people standing close together are 3x more likely to demonstrate helpful behaviors than those exposed to pictures of people standing alone. That's because togetherness and helping others are closely-related. You won't get the same effect if you try to link unrelated concepts like togetherness and cleanliness.
- However, you can construct a link that previously didn't exist just by repeatedly putting 2 objects together. That's why advertisers often use celebrities to promote their products. A Belgian beer increased viewers' positive feelings toward their brand after superimposing their beer 5x on enjoyable activities like cuddling, sailing and waterskiing.



Pre-suasive influences work best when they're subtle or unconscious. We're more susceptible to persuasive cues

## KEY QUOTES

*“Successful openers operate for a communicator. They persuasively channel recipients' attention only to those concepts that are associated favorably with the communicator's particular goal.”*

*“An effective linkage between concepts doesn't have to be located in prevailing reality. It can be constructed.”*

when we lack the time, energy or focus to analyze something in detail. Once we're aware of pre-suasive influences, we respond differently:

- Respondents of a phone survey typically report 20% higher life satisfaction on a sunny day because they're in a better mood. But if the interviewer asks them about the weather before starting the survey, the positive bias disappears. A simple reminder of the pre-suasive cue (weather) can negate its effects.
- When viewers notice obvious product placements in media programs, they recognize the attempt to sway their choices and become less likely to purchase the products.



## Putting Pre-suasion into Action



### The 6 Universal Influence Principles

Pre-suasive methods only work if they're aligned with people's unique goals and circumstances. However, in Cialdini's previous book "Influence", he presented 6 influence principles that're built on the universal human need for social acceptance. You can use these 6 principles in your messages and to pre-suade people *before you even start communicating*.



**Reciprocation.** People tend to say "yes" to those they feel indebted to, e.g. shoppers at a candy store were 42% more likely to buy something if they got a free chocolate at the entrance. To optimize returns:

- Offer the gift/benefit before a request is made (pre-suasion); and
- Ensure it is meaningful, unexpected and customized.

When diners were offered a chocolate (a meaningful gift) at the end of their meals, tips increased 3.3%. When diners were offered a 2nd chocolate (meaningful + unexpected), tips increased 14.1%. When the waitress started to walk away, then returned to offer the 2nd chocolate (meaningful + unexpected + personalized), tips improved 21.3%.

## KEY QUOTES

*"If a gift, favor, or service incorporates all three features of meaningfulness, unexpectedness, and customization, it can become a formidable source of change."*



**Liking.** We prefer to do business with people we like. You can be likeable by being friendly, humorous or attractive. However, Cialdini recommends using 2 practices to show people that you sincerely like *them*, which will naturally lead them like/trust *you* in return:

- Highlight similarities. We like people who're like us (e.g. similar language styles or interests). Waitresses and salespeople who mimic their clients' verbal styles get more tips or sales. Youth mentoring programs are more successful when there're similarities between the mentors and students.
- Give compliments. Everyone likes to be praised, be it for our looks, abilities or personality. Clients who received a compliment from their hairstylist ("You'd look good in any hairstyle") gave 37% more tips.



**Social proof.** When we see others like us responding in a certain way, we'll think that's the right response—morally and practically:

- Validity (it's ok to do it). Research participants expressed support for the military's use of torture after they learned that the majority of their peers also did so. In F&B, a dish can get sold 13-20% more if you add a "most popular" label.
- Feasibility (it's realistic to do it). When residents received a message about how their fellow residents were conserving energy, they saved 3.5x more energy than those who received other energy-conservation messages. Simply hearing about others' energy conservation efforts made it appear feasible and implementable.



**Authority.** The persuasiveness of a message depends more on the perceived authority of the messenger than the content of the message. Authority is about expertise and trustworthiness, not hierarchical status:

- Expertise. When the communicator is perceived to be a subject expert, we tend to follow the advice without much thought.

## KEY QUOTES

*"We like those who are like us."*

*"When a legitimate expert on a topic speaks, people are usually persuaded."*

- Trustworthiness: We're more likely to trust someone who seems honest and unbiased. You can pre-suasively establish your honesty by referring to a weakness early in the communication. This is especially effective when:

- (i) The audience already knows of the weakness; and
- (ii) You use a transitional word (e.g. "but" or "yet") to counteract the weakness with a strength, e.g. "We are new to this market, but we already have a strong presence in 13 other countries."



Scarcity. When something is scarce, we perceive it to be more valuable, and are more averse to losing the chance to acquire it. During a sale, if you add a purchase limit of "X items per customer", you'll probably sell more, not less!



Consistency. We try to act consistently with our past actions and commitments. Once you get people to explicitly agree to something, they're more likely to follow through, even if it takes more time and effort. An organization increased blood donor participation by 12.4% just by asking donors to verbally confirm their attendance: "We'll mark you on the list as coming then, okay? [Pause for confirmation.] Thank you."

»»» Apply these 6 principles in 3 stages in any commercial relationship:

- Stage 1: Build a positive association using reciprocity and liking;
- Stage 2: Reduce uncertainty for decision-making using social proof and authority; and
- Stage 3: Motivate action using consistency and scarcity.



### The 7<sup>th</sup> Principle: Unity & Shared Identity

Besides the 6 principles above, Cialdini discovered a 7<sup>th</sup> principle that strongly affects people's willingness to help one another: the sense of unity and shared identity from human relationships.

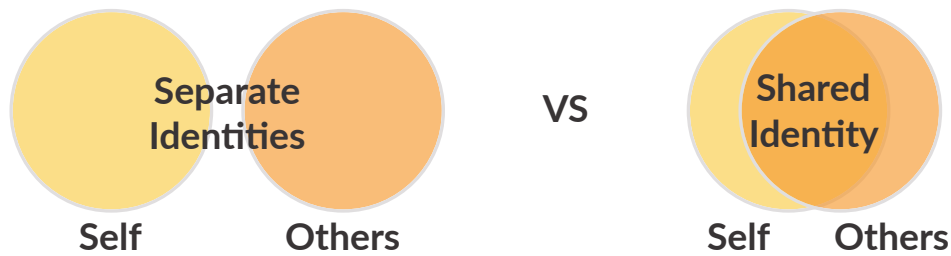
## KEY QUOTES

*"We want more of what we can have less of."*

*"Sometimes all that's necessary is to remind others of a commitment they've made that fits with the practitioners' goals."*

*"Our ability to create change in others is often and importantly grounded in shared personal relationships"*

When we share an identity with others, it goes beyond mere liking or reciprocity—they become one of “us”. For example, we may feel “as one” with people of the same nationality, family or religious affiliation. **This sense of “we-ness” is forged by (i) being together and (ii) acting together.**



**Being together.** We build bonds via kinship and physical proximity.

- **Kinship.** We're biologically programmed to pass on our genes. We're thus inclined to help people in our family who share our bloodline. The use of familial terms (e.g. “brotherhood”, “motherland” or “forefathers”) can trigger feelings of kinship to make us more willing to sacrifice for the group. Or, we may feel greater trust or loyalty for people who treat us “like family”.
- **Physical proximity.** We also develop unity and shared identity with others living in the same place, even if they're not our blood kin. This includes people living in the same house, neighborhood, country or even region (e.g. Asia, Europe). During WWII, Chiune Sugihara sacrificed his career trying to help thousands of Jews escape the Holocaust. This was because as a child, he had watched his parents house and care for people of various nationalities, and had thus developed an expanded definition of “family”.



For thousands of years, humans have been unified by synchronized activities such as marches, rituals, prayers, dances, and songs. **Acting together** (doing something in sync, collaborating or co-creating) can develop a sense of unity or oneness among people.

- **Liking.** When we act in unison with someone, we start to think we're *alike*, and hence develop a *liking* for the person. Participants in a study felt physically connected with strangers on a screen who were also getting their

## KEY QUOTES

*“Relationships not only intensify willingness to help but also cause it.”*

*“From a genetic point of view, being in the same family—the same bloodline—is the ultimate form of self-other unity.”*

*“When people act in unitary ways, they become unitized.”*

*“[The] elevated likeness turns into elevated liking.”*

face brushed in the same way. They even believed that their movements affected the person on the screen and vice versa.

- Synchronized actions can pre-suade people to collaborate and support each other. In a study, participants were split into 2 groups—one group walked together in sync while the other walked normally. Later, both groups played an economic game. Those who walked in step were 50% more cooperative and willing to sacrifice personal gains for their group's success.
- According to Daniel Kahneman, we have 2 cognitive systems: “System 1” is for fast, intuitive and emotional decisions, while “System 2” is for slower, reasoned and logical decisions. When we activate one system, the other is suppressed. Effective persuaders match their approach to the recipients' mindset, e.g. using facts/evidence to appeal to a rational decision-maker, and using feelings to appeal to an intuitive decision-maker.
- Music has the power to unite people, since everyone can simultaneously experience the same beat, rhythm and musical patterns. It also appeals naturally to System 1 thinking to evoke feelings of unity and harmony. Kids who sang and walked together to music were 3x more helpful and selfless to their partners, than those who sang and moved without music.
- When 2 parties repeatedly exchange favors over a period of time, a relationship is formed and it no longer matters who gave the last favor. Pairs of research participants took turns to ask and answer 36 personal questions about each other. By the end of 45 minutes, the participants (who started out as complete strangers) had developed a strong emotional connection.
- Co-creation: People tend to value their own creations more. When we jointly create things, we feel an affinity both for our creation *and* our co-creator.
  - (i) A manager's level of involvement in a project determines how much he likes the outcome. Paradoxically, managers who feel *more* responsible

## KEY QUOTES

*“A history of reciprocally exchanged favors leads individuals to give additional favors to their exchange partner, no matter who provided the last one.”*

for the project's success also attribute *more* success to their co-creators, due to the temporary sense of shared identity from co-creation.

- (ii) When you ask someone for advice, they'll feel as if they've co-created the solution with you. So, instead of merely asking for customers' opinions or feedbacks, companies should explicitly ask customers for their *advice*.



### Pre-suading Ethically

✗ Pre-suasion can be an extremely powerful source of influence. However, this also raises ethical concerns since they can be used to trick or mislead consumers. Most CEOs know that unethical practices can bring irreparable financial and reputational damage to their companies. Yet, 50% would still engage in malpractice just to reap short-term gains, thinking they won't get caught.

✓ Cialdini urges readers to act responsibly, as the long-term costs are simply not worth the short-term gains. Unethical actions will eventually catch up with you in at least 3 ways:

- Employee performance: When employees act against their ethical values, it creates moral stress that causes fatigue, lower morale and a loss of enthusiasm, all of which reduce work performance and profitability.
- Staff turnover: Stress and unhappiness at work can lead to 30% higher turnover. On average, each staff turnover can cost the equivalent of 1-year's remuneration for that employee.
- Employee fraud and misconduct: The type of employees who'll stay are also those who're likely to cheat and take advantage of the company.

## KEY QUOTES

*"Just because we can use psychological tactics to gain consent doesn't mean we are entitled to them."*

*"Those who cheat for you will cheat against you."*



## Post-Suasion: Ensuring Continuity

How can you ensure that your pre-suasive efforts will continue to deliver results, especially when others also start to use pre-suasive techniques? There are 2 additional strategies to create lasting change:



**Create strong commitments.** Pre-suasive openers can trigger immediate behavioral shifts. However, to lock in lasting change, you must secure commitments for future action, and ideally incorporate the behaviors into people's sense of identity. For instance, you can increase the chances of someone showing up for a group coaching session by getting them to fill up the appointment card (instead of you doing it for them). Other related actions (e.g. making a deposit, doing pre-coaching activities or plugging in to a coaching community) can all reinforce their commitment to repeatedly attend the sessions until it's a part of who they are.



**Design your cues and environments.** In our fast-paced modern societies, we're constantly bombarded by distractions and stimuli. Use the ideas in this book to design your external living/work spaces so you're constantly surrounded by, and focusing on, cues and stimuli that support your goals. Take systematic control of your surroundings instead of allowing others to influence you with *their* cues.



## Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This book includes many other detailed research studies and examples to show how pre-suasive techniques can be used to influence decisions and behaviors, and how you can harness pre-suasion to achieve your goals. For more details, please visit [www.influenceatwork.com](http://www.influenceatwork.com).

## KEY QUOTES

*"Pre-suasive openers can produce dramatic, immediate shifts in people, but to turn those shifts into durable changes, it's necessary to get commitments to them, usually in the form of related behavior."*

*"In large measure, who we are with respect to any choice is where we are, attentionally, in the moment before the choice."*